CHAPTER 6 · DEEP DIVE · HOUSE & DIVIDED

The Caning of Sumner

The day the violence of Bleeding Kansas walked into the United States Senate. May 1856.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

The day the violence of Bleeding Kansas walked into the United States Senate. May 1856.

When the same event is cheered in one half of the country and mourned in the other, what does that tell you about where the nation was heading?

“The Crime Against Kansas”

MAY 19–20, 1856

Senator Charles Sumner of Massachusetts rose to give a two-day speech raging against the violence in Kansas. He did not hold back — he personally mocked an elderly Southern senator, Andrew Butler of South Carolina, in cruel and insulting terms.

It was a blistering, deliberately personal attack. In the tense spring of 1856, with Kansas already bleeding, those words were gasoline near a flame.

“Southern Chivalry — Argument versus Club's” — lithograph by John L. Magee, 1856, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Attack

MAY 22, 1856

Three days later, Butler's cousin — Congressman Preston Brooks of South Carolina — walked onto the floor of the Senate, found Sumner at his desk, and beat him over the head with a heavy cane until it shattered.

Sumner, trapped under his bolted desk, was left bloody and unconscious. His injuries were so severe it took him three years to return to the Senate. To Brooks, it was not a crime — it was defending his family's honor the way a Southern gentleman should.

Charles Sumner — photograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

“Southern Chivalry”

THE NORTHERN VIEW

Northern artists turned the attack into propaganda. Notice the sarcasm in the title — and who is drawn as helpless, who as brutal.

“Southern Chivalry — Argument versus Club's” — lithograph by John L. Magee, 1856, public domain (Library of Congress).

A Country Splits Over One Beating

TWO REACTIONS

Here is the astonishing part. The North was horrified — Sumner became a martyr for free speech, and hundreds of thousands of copies of his speech were printed. The attack drove voters toward the new Republican Party.

The South cheered. Brooks was celebrated as a hero; admirers mailed him dozens of new canes to replace the one he broke, some inscribed “Hit him again.” One beating, two completely opposite reactions — that gap was the coming war.

“Southern Chivalry — Argument versus Club's” — lithograph by John L. Magee, 1856, public domain (Library of Congress).

PRESTON BROOKS, ON THE FLOOR OF CONGRESS

If I desired to kill the Senator, why did I not do it? … I did not intend to kill him, but I did intend to whip him.

When Words Stop Working

WHY IT MATTERS

The Senate was supposed to be the one place where the slavery fight stayed a fight of words. After May 22, 1856, even that was gone.

If a senator could be beaten nearly to death at his desk — and half the country applauded — then the argument was no longer really about Kansas. It was about whether the two halves of the nation could share a government at all.

“Southern Chivalry — Argument versus Club's” — lithograph by John L. Magee, 1856, public domain (Library of Congress).

Same Event, Two Nations

YOUR TURN

You'll read how Northern and Southern newspapers described the very same attack — and use a historian's skill called point of view to explain why they saw it so differently.